

Case Study 10

The Milgram Obedience Experiments

In July 1961, Stanley Milgram, a 28-year-old recent Ph.D. graduate from Harvard, began a series of obedience experiments. He was conducting social psychology research regarding the external social forces that, though subtle, have surprisingly powerful effects on human behavior.

The Experiment

Participants in the study were told they were part of an experiment researching the relationship between punishment and learning. A “lead” experimenter, who did not coerce or compel the participants in any way, instructed participants to shock a learner by pressing a lever on a machine each time the learner made a mistake on a word-matching task. If learners continued to make mistakes, the test subjects were told to increase the intensity of the shocks by 15-volt increments. The shock intensity started at 15 volts and, if enough errors were made, could reach 450 volts.



Milgram found that an average and presumably normal group of participants would willingly inflict very painful and perhaps even harmful electric shocks on innocent victims.

In actuality, the shock machine was non-functional and the learner was an actor who did not actually get shocked. The experiment revealed that a majority of the participants continued to obey the lead experimenter, delivering shocks up to 450 volts, simply because the experimenter commanded them to.

Although participants were told about the deception upon completing the experiment, many found the experience to be very real and gripping. Later that year, the headline of an article in the October 26 issue of *The New York Times* proclaimed, "Sixty-five Percent in Test Blindly Obey Order to Inflict Pain." This article instigated much discussion about the ordeal Milgram put his subjects through and began the enduring discussion of the ethics of such experimentation.

Milgram's experiments (he conducted over 20 variations of the experiment) have had long-lasting significance in that they demonstrated clearly that normal individuals could be induced to act destructively, even in the absence of physical coercion. People do not need to be innately evil or aberrant to act in ways that are reprehensible and inhumane. Many scientists suspect this is what happened in WWII when millions of Jewish people were tortured.

Related Studies

Professionals in many fields (such as nursing, marketing, accounting) have performed similar tests to determine the extent to which people will comply with requests that seem unethical. For example, Steven Hartwell, a law professor at the University of San Diego, conducted an experiment whereby his students were to advise a client individually in a small-claims court.

Hartwell writes:

The "clients" were, in fact, a single confederate who sought the same advice from each student: how she should present her side of a rent dispute. I told each student to advise the client to lie under oath that she had paid the rent. When students asked for clarification, I uniformly responded, "...My advice is that, if your client wants to win her case, then you must tell her to perjure herself." ...We wanted them to experience the pull between loyalty to authority... and prescribed ethical conduct Although many of the 24 participating students grumbled either to me or to the client about my proffered advice, 23 told their client to perjure herself.

Lesson Learned

Even without Milgram's obedience studies, psychologists knew that people have a tendency to obey orders. The surprising part of his experiments was learning about the strength of the tendency. Because of the knowledge gained, we can try to guard against following such unethical commands. The U.S. Army has taken these studies seriously and all officers are required to enroll in two psychology courses at the Military Academy. In 1985, the head of the academy's department of behavioural sciences and leadership wrote, "One of the desired outcomes of this is that our future military leaders will be fully cognizant not only of their authority but also of their responsibility to make decisions that are well considered and morally sound."